



PRIDE AND PREJUDICE

A Novel of Manners



JANE AUSTEN

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Chapter One — A Household in Want of News

It is a truth quietly agreed upon in every drawing room of the county that a family with five daughters and no great fortune must take a keen interest in the arrival of any single gentleman of means.

Mrs. Bennington had scarcely finished her tea before the news reached her: Netherfield Park was let at last, and to a young man of considerable income and, it was rumoured, considerable charm.

"You must go and call on him at once," she informed her husband, who continued reading his paper with the particular calm of a man who has heard this sentence many times before.

Chapter Two — The Assembly

The assembly rooms were bright with candles and brighter still with speculation, for the new tenant of Netherfield had arrived with a friend whose reserve was mistaken, by nearly everyone, for pride.

Elisabeth watched the pair cross the room with the detached amusement of someone who has already decided the evening will furnish her with several excellent stories, whatever else it fails to provide.

It was not admiration she felt when their eyes briefly met across the crowded floor — or so she told herself, twice, before the dance resumed.